

ITSS Learn — National Certificate: IT Systems Support (SAQA 48573)

Conduct a technical practitioners meeting

Unit Standard 114051 · NQF Level 5 · 4 Credits

Meeting types · Leadership styles · Decision-making · Conventions
Preparation · Chairing · Post-meeting follow-up

Specific Outcome 1

Demonstrate knowledge of different types of technical practitioners meetings

Conduct a technical practitioners meeting — introduction

Time: 90 minutes · Activity: Self & Group.

Unit Standard 114051 — Conduct a technical practitioners meeting. In this lesson you will be assessed against these specific outcomes and related assessment criteria: the demonstration describes the types of technical meetings and their uses (contract meetings, technical review meetings, project review meetings); the demonstration identifies leadership styles used in meeting procedures (democratic, autocratic, facilitative); and the demonstration identifies decision-making processes used in meetings (voting, consensus, criteria-based rating, ranking, paired comparisons).

Meetings are very important for the work of any organisation. Good meetings are important for collective decision-making, planning and follow-up, accountability, democracy, and other practices that will help you to build a good organisation.

The principal activities of a technical committee are the development and maintenance of its associated standards, technical reports, and data files in accordance with the purpose of the organisation.

Different types of technical practitioners meetings

There are different types of meetings and planning should take account of this. Most organisations will hold general members meetings, special meetings, executive meetings, and annual general meetings. However, for technical practitioners, three key meeting types are most relevant:

Contract meetings are held to discuss, review, and manage contractual obligations and deliverables related to technical projects or services.

Technical review meetings are conducted to evaluate technical solutions, designs, implementations, and to resolve technical issues and problems.

Project review meetings are held to assess project progress, timelines, resource allocation, and project deliverables.

Leadership styles in meetings

There are three main leadership styles used in meeting procedures: democratic, autocratic, and facilitative.

Democratic meetings are held with appointed or nominated delegates from departments, organisations or areas. These delegates will be given the information and the meeting will be conducted in this manner. All members have a voice and participate in decision-making.

Autocratic meetings are hosted and led by a chairperson who will run the entire meeting and will give most of the input. The other attendees will be required to give input only when instructed. Decision-making is centralised and controlled by the chair.

Facilitative meetings are group efforts where the leader sets a trend of ensuring that all members are actively participating in the meeting to achieve the outcome or goal. The facilitator guides discussion while enabling full participation.

Decision-making processes in meetings

Meetings use various decision-making processes to arrive at conclusions and take action. The main processes are: voting, consensus, criteria-based rating, ranking, and paired comparisons.

Voting is a direct democratic process where each participant votes, typically by show of hands or ballot, and the option with the most votes wins. Simple majority (50% + 1) or supermajority (two-thirds or 75%) rules may apply.

Consensus means that all participants agree or at least can accept the decision. It requires discussion and compromise until all can support the outcome.

Criteria-based rating involves evaluating options against predetermined criteria and rating each option on each criterion, then scoring to identify the best option.

Ranking involves having participants rank options from best to worst, with scores assigned based on ranking position, then totaling scores across all participants.

Paired comparisons involve comparing options two at a time, with participants indicating their preference for each pair, and then scoring based on how many times each option is preferred.

Meeting conventions and procedures

Good meetings follow established conventions and procedures to ensure order, fairness, and effectiveness. Key conventions include moving, seconding, amending, and voting procedures.

Moving means formally proposing a resolution or course of action. A mover states their proposal clearly: 'I move that we...'

Seconding means supporting a motion by indicating another member agrees it is worthy of discussion. A seconder says: 'I second that motion.'

Amending means modifying a motion before voting. Amendments can change the wording, scope, or terms of the original motion. All amendments must be voted on.

Voting procedures ensure fair counting of votes. They include methods for raising hands, show of hands, ballot voting, and recording abstentions (members not voting either way).

An important note: the note taker should have technical background knowledge. This ensures that technical terminology is correctly recorded and that technical context is properly understood and documented in the minutes.

Specific Outcome 2

Prepare for a technical practitioners meeting

Preparing for a technical practitioners meeting

Time: 90 minutes · Activity: Self & Group.

When meetings are arranged, the outcome of such meetings is heavily dependent on the preparation and input into the meetings. Proper preparation ensures clarity, engagement, and successful outcomes.

Venue selection is critical. The size and interactive capabilities of the venue will heavily affect the meeting outcome. The venue must be able to accommodate required group movements and activities. Location accessibility affects participant turnout. The venue should be positioned to minimise distractions.

Facilities must be appropriate to the meeting type and outcomes required. These may include tables, chairs, flipcharts, whiteboards, screens, audio/visual equipment, and breakout spaces for group work.

Technology requirements depend on the meeting type. Online meetings may require internet access and video conferencing software. Technical demonstrations may require specific equipment or software access.

Relevant supporting information includes user guides, manuals, reference documents, and background information that participants need to understand the meeting topics and prepare adequately.

Meeting outcomes must be clear, concise, and well-documented. Participants need to understand what the meeting aims to achieve and what outputs are expected.

Meeting invitations must be extended timeously to all relevant participants, giving them sufficient time to prepare and arrange their schedules.

The meeting agenda and supporting documentation must be completed and distributed before the meeting, ideally a week in advance.

Specific Outcome 3

Chair a technical practitioners meeting

Chairing a technical practitioners meeting

Time: 90 minutes · Activity: Self & Group.

The chairperson is the most important person in the meeting. They will set the pace, ensure people stick to topics, ensure democratic decisions are taken, and ensure everyone agrees with these decisions.

Before the meeting starts, the chair and members should agree on rules and guidelines on behaviour to ensure smooth and respectful proceedings.

The chair must apply agreed meeting conventions throughout the meeting, according to the type of meeting and in accordance with the standing procedures of the organisation involved.

The chair should ensure that the published agenda is followed, keeping discussion on track and allocating time according to topic importance.

The chair must provide for active participation by all members to avoid or minimise conflict. This includes managing difficult behaviours: the heckler, the overly talkative person, the cynic, the silent member, conflicting egos, side conversations, and factually wrong statements.

The chair should ensure that meeting topics are prioritised and that discussion times are allocated according to importance, urgency, and complexity.

Most importantly, the chair must ensure that agreed decisions are clear, accurate, include a time frame for action, and are within the mandate of the type of meeting being conducted.

Specific Outcome 4

Conduct post-meeting follow-up for a technical meeting

Conducting post-meeting follow-up for a technical meeting

Time: 90 minutes · Activity: Self & Group.

There has been much emphasis on group decision support systems but little attention has been paid to the implementation stage that follows a decision meeting. The gap between the end of a meeting and its post-meeting activities may turn the decision inconsequential, due to inappropriate support to the implementation stage.

Decisions that are implemented without necessary follow-up may generate outcomes different from those planned at the time of the decision. Supporting post-decision activities and linking them to the corresponding decision meeting are essential to make the meeting cycle fully successful.

Post-meeting support includes four key aspects: the decision implementation plan; the follow-up of implementation activities; support for interaction between decision makers and implementers; and awareness support to external members.

The follow-up ensures that minutes of the meeting are produced accurately and in line with the policy of the organisation. Minutes serve as a reminder of issues that need follow-up and prevent arguments about previous decisions.

The follow-up communicates agreed records of discussion to interested parties in a format and timeframe that meet requirements of the type of meeting and of the organisation involved.

The follow-up includes a summary of discussions and actions, and meets format requirements. This ensures clarity about what was discussed and what actions need to be taken by whom and when.

Self-assessment and competency checklist

Once you have completed all the lessons and questions for Unit Standard 114051, you need to check the progress you have made. Below is a competency checklist to help you assess your understanding.

You should be able to demonstrate:

Knowledge of different types of technical practitioners meetings and their purposes

Understanding of leadership styles (democratic, autocratic, facilitative) and their applications

Knowledge of decision-making processes (voting, consensus, criteria-based rating, ranking, paired comparisons)

Ability to prepare adequately for technical meetings including venue, facilities, technology, and documentation

Skills to chair meetings effectively, manage discussions, and ensure productive outcomes

Ability to conduct post-meeting follow-up including accurate minutes and action tracking

- I am able to describe different types of technical practitioners meetings and their uses
- I am able to identify leadership styles used in meeting procedures
- I am able to identify decision-making processes used in meetings
- I am able to prepare for a technical practitioners meeting
- I am able to chair a technical practitioners meeting
- I am able to conduct post-meeting follow-up for a technical meeting